

EmoType-Zero: Adaptive Fonts to Render the Speech Emotion

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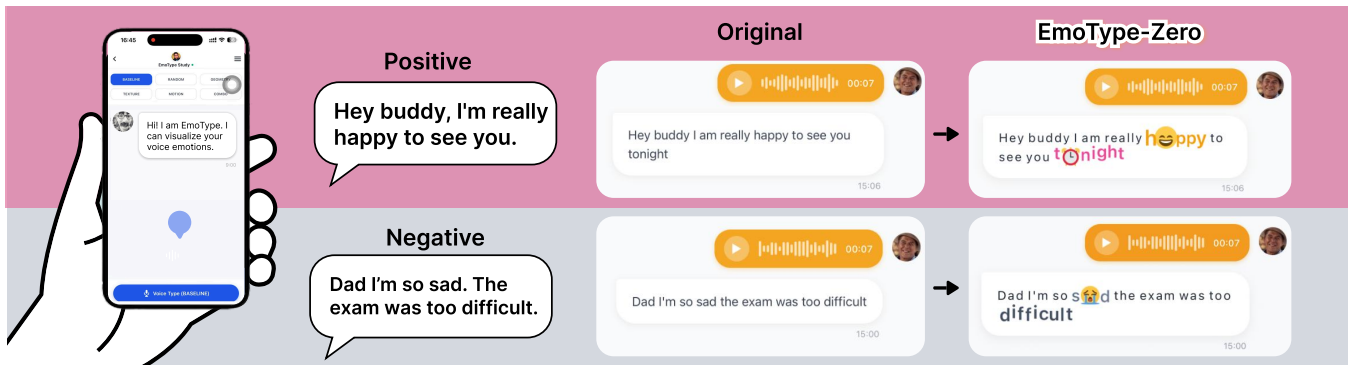


Figure 1: EmoType-Zero restores the emotional signals lost in voice-to-text transcription.

Abstract

Text messaging often lacks paralinguistic cues essential for interpreting emotional tone. To explore visual alternatives, we first conducted a co-design study with 9 participants to distill a design space mapping vocal intonations to visual parameters (Geometry, Texture, and Motion). We developed EmoType-Zero, a research probe to operationalize these concepts. We then deployed this probe in a user study with 25 participants to empirically evaluate user perceptions. Results reveal a critical design trade-off: while the COMBO mode (combining geometry, texture, and motion) achieved the highest emotional fidelity (mean ranking: $M = 1.60$, rank 1=best), its visual complexity compromised text legibility ($M = 4.56$). Consequently, participants preferred the subtle GEOMETRY mode ($M = 2.24$) for daily usage, prioritizing clarity over high-intensity effects. Subjective feedback validated the probe's utility, with 80% of participants agreeing that it improved emotional understanding and 72% expressing willingness to adopt the system for situational impairments and social modulation.

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CCS Concepts

• Human-centered computing → Interaction techniques.

Keywords

Voice Input, Speech-to-Text, Emotional Kinetic Typography, Affective Computing

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1 Introduction

Instant messaging has become the primary substrate for maintaining everyday relationships, yet the reduction of speech to plain text filters out essential paralinguistic cues—such as tone, pitch, and cadence—that convey intent and empathy [16]. While voice interaction (e.g., voice typing) is rapidly becoming ubiquitous, offering a rich source of vocal data, current transcription technologies treat speech purely as linguistic content. They extract words but discard the vocal nuances the moment text is generated. We argue that this process is unnecessarily *lossy*: it strips away the speaker's emotional reality, forcing users to shoulder the *authoring burden* of manually annotating messages with emojis to clarify their tone [5].

This disconnect presents a critical design opportunity. While prior research has explored kinetic typography to restore expressiveness, existing approaches largely rely on laborious manual editing [1] or focus on passive consumption contexts like captioning [15]. There is a lack of automated, real-time solutions designed for the active, rapid-fire nature of instant messaging. To address this, we frame our inquiry around the following research question: *How can we translate vocal emotion into kinetic typography to enhance expressiveness in instant messaging without compromising legibility, and which visual strategies are most effective?*

To explore this, we first conducted a co-design study to distill a design space for mapping paralinguistic cues to visual parameters (Geometry, Texture, and Motion). Grounded in these findings, we developed EmoType-Zero, an initial research probe designed to operationalize these concepts. Unlike rigid rule-based tools, our system leverages a Large Language Model (LLM) to dynamically map vocal inputs to kinetic typography. This prototype serves as a research probe to empirically explore the utility and trade-offs within our proposed design space in realistic messaging scenarios.

Our empirical evaluation reveals a fundamental tension in affective text design. While the integrated COMBO mode (combining geometry, texture, and motion) was identified as the most effective for emotional fidelity, participants ultimately preferred the subtle GEOMETRY mode for daily usage. This preference highlights a critical balance: users prioritize the clarity of GEOMETRY over the high intensity of COMBO, despite the latter's superior expressiveness. Beyond these design trade-offs, subjective feedback validated the system's practical value. On a 5-point Likert scale, the vast majority of participants (80%) agreed that the expressive typography enhanced emotional understanding ($M = 4.12$), and 72% expressed willingness to adopt the system in their daily messaging ($M = 3.80$).

2 Related Work

Voice Typing: From Efficiency to Expressiveness. HCI research on voice-based text entry has predominantly prioritized efficiency and usability. Prior work has extensively optimized interaction techniques for dictation, focusing on error correction strategies on touch devices [8, 18] and multimodal editing workflows. While these contributions establish voice typing as a robust input method, they treat the resulting transcript strictly as lexical content, effectively stripping away the rich paralinguistic cues (e.g., emotion, prosody, intensity) inherent in speech. Our work shifts this focus from transcription accuracy to emotional fidelity, treating voice typing as a channel that should preserve the speaker's expressive intent.

Visualizing Voice: Kinetic Typography and Affective Captions. To bridge the gap between text and emotion, researchers have long explored kinetic typography. Foundational systems enabled users to manually author expressive text animations to convey tone [1, 7, 9]. However, the high interaction cost of manual styling is impractical for rapid instant messaging. To automate this, recent work maps acoustic features directly to visual variables. This includes *speech-modulated typography* that distorts letterforms based on sound signals [3, 6, 14], and affective captioning systems designed for storytelling [15] or accessibility contexts like VR and video consumption [4, 12, 17]. Despite these advances, existing automated

systems often target passive consumption (e.g., reading stories, watching videos) or produce heavy graphical distortions. Our work extends this lineage by integrating semantic-aware, voice-driven kinetic typography directly into the *text production* workflow of everyday instant messaging, ensuring the output remains lightweight, readable, and editable.

3 Design Space for Emotional Kinetic Typography

3.1 Data Collection and Analysis

Participants and Materials. We recruited 9 long-term voice typing users (5 females, 4 males; aged 20–35), including 5 participants with an HCI background and 4 with design-related training/experience (one with professional editorial typography experience; see Table 1 in Appendix). About the co-design materials, we prepared a curated set of “emotional typography” examples collected from prior work [1, 2, 4, 9, 10, 15] and design references to support review and group discussion. We also selected four short audio clips spanning the quadrants of Russell's Circumplex Model to drive the subsequent creation tasks: High-Arousal/Positive (excited sports commentary, “This is for the win!”), Low-Arousal/Negative (suppressed monologue, “I am in pain”), High-Arousal/Negative (panicked cry, “Please! No!”), and Low-Arousal/Positive (calm gratitude, “I am grateful to be here”). Participants worked on structured design sheets that included an audio-feature annotation block (pitch, speed, volume, emotion) and a sketching canvas.

Procedure. The co-design workshop consisted of three sub-sessions. (1) *Review and discussion*: participants reviewed the collected typography examples and discussed how visual attributes could convey vocal tone under voice-typing constraints. (2) *Guided creation*: participants performed a visual transcription task by sketching kinetic-typography designs for the four audio clips, followed by voting and group discussion of rationale and trade-offs. (3) *Open creation*: participants designed for self-chosen voice-typed phrases and contexts, with open-ended discussion.

Data Analysis. We recorded the workshop with permission, transcribed discussions, and collected all design artifacts and votes. Three authors conducted iterative thematic analysis. We first performed open coding to capture links between emotion cues and visual choices, as well as constraints related to readability, editability, and lightweight rendering. We then used axial coding to synthesize recurring patterns into a text-centric design space and mapping guidelines organized around *Metaphor*, *Form*, and *Motion*.

3.2 Design Space: Emotional Kinetic Typography for Voice Typing

Based on the co-design artifacts and the thematic analysis, we synthesized a design space that characterizes how emotional cues in spoken input can be expressed through kinetic typography in voice typing (Fig. 2). Informed by participants' representational strategies, prior studies on expressive and kinetic typography [1, 2, 4, 9, 10, 15], and the readability and attentional constraints of instant messaging—where excessive visual dynamics can disrupt text processing [13]—the design space organizes emotional expression along three complementary layers: *Geometry*, *Texture*, and *Motion*.

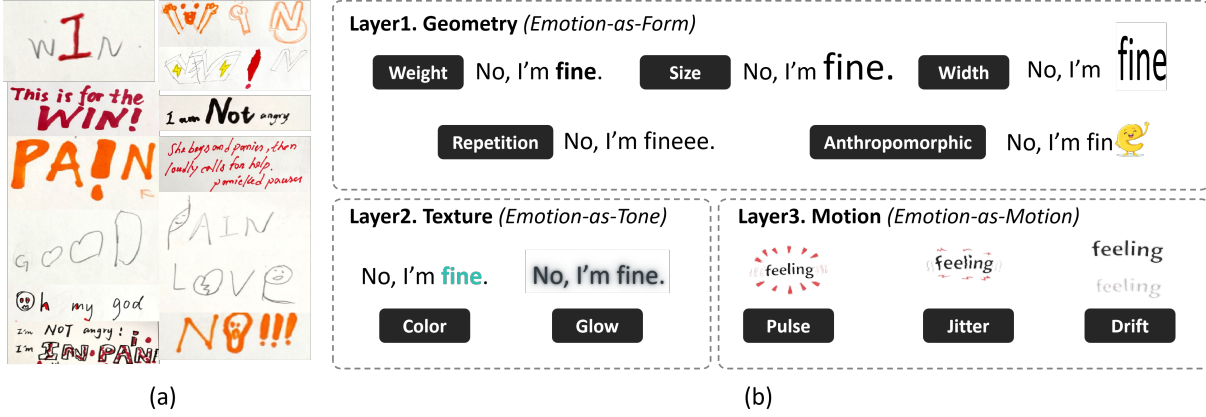


Figure 2: Design space of expressive typography for emotion in voice typing. (a) A subset of co-design artifacts collected from participatory workshops. (b) A three-layer design space synthesized from the artifacts and informed by prior studies [1, 2, 4, 9, 10, 15] including geometry, texture, and motion for emotional expression in instant messaging. (See Figure 6 in Appendix for comprehensive examples.)

Layer 1: Geometry (Emotion-as-Form). This layer captures structural manipulations of letterforms that participants used to convey emotional emphasis and intensity. Common strategies included adjusting *weight*, *size*, and *width* to amplify perceived emotional strength, using *repetition* to signal heightened arousal, and selectively introducing *anthropomorphic* or pictorial letterforms to externalize affect. These form-level changes were frequently described as direct, legible, and well-suited to rapid voice-typed communication.

Layer 2: Texture (Emotion-as-Tone). Texture-level treatments modulate the affective tone of text without altering its basic structure. Participants primarily explored *color* to reflect emotional polarity and intensity, while effects such as *glow* were discussed as digital extensions of handwritten emphasis (e.g., heavy strokes or visual salience). These treatments were perceived as lightweight cues that preserve readability while enriching emotional nuance.

Layer 3: Motion (Emotion-as-Motion). Beyond static typography, participants frequently alluded to dynamic qualities—such as trembling, pulsing, or fading—when describing emotional speech. We abstracted these cues into three motion primitives: *pulse*, *jitter*, and *drift*, which translate implied vocal dynamics into subtle temporal behaviors suitable for instant messaging contexts. Motion was viewed as a powerful but sensitive channel, requiring careful calibration to avoid distraction or disruption.

4 EmoType-Zero

To operationalize the proposed design space and empirically validate the efficacy of its dimensions (Geometry, Texture, and Motion), we developed EmoType-Zero. It is a real-time web-based prototype (React frontend, Python backend) capable of switching between six distinct rendering modes (Baseline, Random, Geometry, Texture, Motion, and Combo). As illustrated in Figure 3, the system pipeline functions as an end-to-end multimodal loop: it captures vocal input via the Web Audio API and transmits audio data to the backend for acoustic (Wav2vec) and semantic analysis. To ensure robustness and generalization across open-ended inputs, the system employs a Large Language Model (GPT-5) as the core reasoning

engine. Unlike rigid rule-based approaches, the LLM maps complex semantics and paralinguistic cues into a structured JSON rendering schema. This schema drives the frontend kinetic engine to generate expressive typography dynamically. Notably, we implemented a lightweight approximation using a curated set of 23 common emojis to proxy anthropomorphic forms; this approach preserves the “emotion-as-form” metaphor while satisfying the low-latency computation constraints required for seamless mobile interaction.

5 User Study

5.1 Participants and Procedure

We conducted an exploratory study to investigate user perceptions of the proposed design strategies (Geometry, Texture, Motion). The study was designed to elicit deep insights into the trade-offs between emotional expressiveness, legibility, and aesthetics across the six rendering modes (Baseline, Random, Geometry, Texture, Motion, Combo; see Figure 4). We recruited 25 participants (15 males, 10 females, aged 20–36). The session began with a 10-minute introduction to the system pipeline. This was followed by a performance phase comprising both *Scripted Tasks*—recording prepared lines covering four emotional quadrants (Joy, Anger, Sadness, Warmth)—and *Freestyle Tasks*, where participants improvised personally relevant messages. Finally, the session concluded with a post-task questionnaire (see Appendix B) regarding user preferences and a semi-structured interview to gather qualitative insights.

5.2 Results and Findings

Following the user study, we analyzed the quantitative data from the questionnaires and the qualitative insights from the semi-structured interviews. Our evaluation revealed three key findings regarding the design trade-offs, user preferences, and practical utility.

Finding 1: Motion is the most effective driver of emotional arousal, but excessive dynamism compromises readability. Quantitative rankings confirmed that dynamic modes are superior for emotional expression, with COMBO ($M = 1.60$) and MOTION ($M = 2.40$) significantly outperforming static styles. Participants described motion as “infectious,” noting that the movement itself

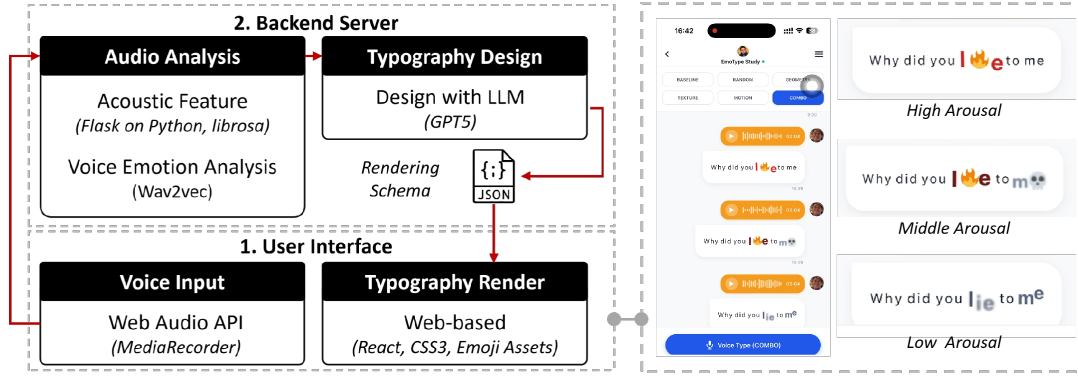


Figure 3: System architecture of EmoType-Zero. The pipeline captures vocal input via the Web Audio API, processes acoustic features (Wav2vec) and semantics (LLM) on the backend, and generates a JSON rendering schema to drive the React-based kinetic typography engine. Right: The mobile chat interface demonstrated on an iPhone 16 Pro Max, showing effects across different arousal levels.

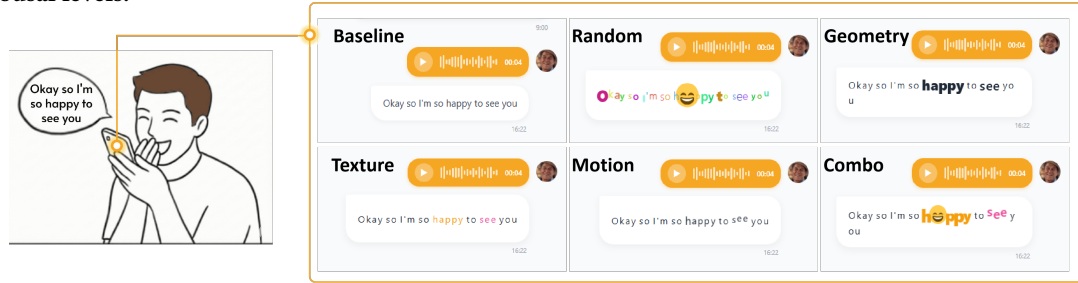


Figure 4: An example comparing the six rendering modes used in the evaluation, including the isolated design layers (Geometry, Texture, Motion), the integrated Combo mode, and the Baseline/Random controls.

Comparative Ranking :

- Q1: Please rank the 6 modes based on your **Overall Preference**
- Q2: Please rank the 6 modes based on **Emotional Expressiveness**
- Q3: Please rank the 6 modes based on **Legibility**
- Q4: Please rank the 6 modes based on **Visual Aesthetics**

Subjective User Experience:

- Q5: I would be willing to use expressive typography like this in daily messaging.
- Q6: Expressive typography helped me better understand emotional tone.
- Q7: I would continue using expressive typography if it were available in my messaging app.
- Q8: This expressive typography was easy to learn and use.

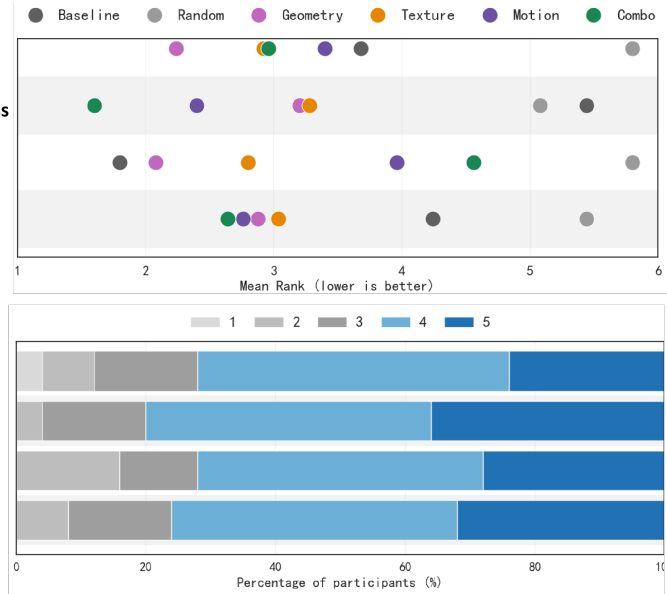


Figure 5: Mean rankings of six visual modes (Top) and subjective user experience ratings (1-5 Likert points, Bottom).

acted as a direct visual metaphor for vocal energy. However, this high expressiveness comes with a distinct cost: continuous animation creates visual noise that distracts from the textual content ($M_{legibility} = 4.56$ for COMBO, $M_{legibility} = 4.00$ for MOTION). To

balance this trade-off, qualitative feedback suggests two complementary design strategies. First, *bounded dynamism*: motion should be fleeting—active for only “1–2 seconds”—before stabilizing. Second, given subjective differences in visual tolerance, the system

should offer a *configurable intensity* setting, allowing users to manually scale the amplitude of motion effects to match their personal reading comfort.

Finding 2: Users prioritize GEOMETRY as the sustainable default, reserving dynamic effects for high-arousal emphasis. Participants' rankings revealed a distinct hierarchy in visual acceptance. GEOMETRY ($M = 2.24$) emerged as the preferred "Golden Mean," balancing emotional clarity with reading stability. Interviews attribute this to its resemblance to familiar typographic emphasis (e.g., weight, size), allowing it to convey tone without disrupting the static nature of text. However, this does not render high-fidelity modes obsolete. Participants explicitly noted that while GEOMETRY should serve as the standard visualization, TEXTURE and MOTION remain essential for conveying specific, high-intensity emotions. This suggests that optimal affective design is not about choosing one single mode, but employing a layered strategy: using GEOMETRY as the ubiquitous baseline, while strategically layering TEXTURE or MOTION only when the emotional arousal crosses a critical threshold.

Finding 3: Kinetic typography is essential for restoring the emotion in speech-to-text communication. Most participants (80%) agreed that the kinetic typography successfully bridged the emotional gap of plain text, transforming a functional transcription into an engaging social experience. Crucially, this appeal is universal: our analysis showed a negligible correlation ($r = 0.06$) between daily voice usage and adoption intent, meaning that heavy users and light users are equally eager to use the system. Participants viewed these dynamics not as decoration, but as a critical semantic layer. P15 described the system as a necessary "visual subtitle" that allows voice messages to be consumed in silent meetings without losing the sender's tone. Similarly, P3 emphasized its social value, noting that "seeing the text tremble makes the message feel alive," which helps soften the tone and reduce ambiguity. Consequently, 72% of users expressed a strong intent to adopt the system, confirming that visualizing paralinguistic cues is key to modernizing digital interaction.

6 Conclusion and Future Work

In this work, we presented **EmoType-Zero**, a research probe that reimagines the traditional speech-to-text process by systematically embedding paralinguistic cues into visual forms. Rather than serving merely as a transcription tool, our system acts as an affective bridge, restoring the non-verbal nuances typically lost in digitization. The strong user willingness to adopt this paradigm (72% intent to use, $M = 3.80$) motivates us to evolve the current prototype into **EmoType**, a fully realized, ubiquitous communication interface.

Future development will optimize **EmoType** across three critical dimensions. First, to address the latency constraints identified in our benchmark (Avg=2.3s, $SD = 0.5$ on 50 samples), we will migrate from cloud inference to on-device Small Language Models (SLMs) to ensure real-time responsiveness. Second, we focus on personalization and legible anthropomorphism [11]; this involves learning individual users' expression preferences and refining the "living" behaviors of text so that high-arousal animations remain readable. Finally, we will develop specialized modes for accessibility,

deeply adapting the visual parameters to serve as a robust auxiliary channel for DHH (Deaf and Hard of Hearing) communities in face-to-face interactions.

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A Supplemental Materials for Co-design Study

Table 1 details the demographics, academic backgrounds, and voice-typing habits of the nine workshop participants of our co-design study. Additionally, Figure 6 provides a comprehensive visual inventory of the co-design outcomes, mapping raw participant sketches to the design space (Geometry, Texture, Motion) to demonstrate the empirical evidence behind our visual variables.

Table 1: Demographic Information and Usage Habits of Workshop Participants. *Design Confidence* reflects the participant's self-reported comfort with the sketching task.

ID	Gender	Age	Education	Voice Typing Usage	Design Confidence
P1	F	22	Design	Daily	High
P2	M	21	HCI	Weekly	Low
P3	F	23	Digital Media Art	Daily	High
P4	M	24	HCI	Weekly	Medium
P5	F	22	HCI	Daily	Medium
P6	M	35	HCI	Daily	Low
P7	F	21	Journalism	Daily	High
P8	M	20	Design	Daily	High
P9	F	23	HCI	Weekly	Medium

B Post-task Questionnaire and Semi-structured Interview Protocol

The following items were administered to participants immediately after the task session.

Part 1: Comparative Ranking

- **Q1:** Please rank the 6 modes based on your **overall preference**, considering the trade-off between emotional expression and readability.
- **Q2:** Please rank the 6 modes based on **Emotional Expressiveness** (i.e., how strongly and accurately they conveyed the emotion behind the voice).
- **Q3:** Please rank the 6 modes based on **Legibility** (i.e., how easy it was to read and recognize the text content).
- **Q4:** Please rank the 6 modes based on **Visual Aesthetics** (i.e., how visually appealing and attractive you found the design).

Part 2: Subjective User Experience

Participants rated their agreement with the following statements (Q5–Q8) on a 5-point Likert scale (1=Strongly Disagree, 5=Strongly Agree).

- **Q5:** I would be willing to use expressive typography like this in my daily messaging.
- **Q6:** The expressive typography helped me better understand the emotional tone of the message.
- **Q7:** If this feature were available in my current messaging app, I would continue using it.
- **Q8:** The system was easy to learn and use.

Part 3: Semi-structured Interview Protocol

- **Q9:** Can you imagine a specific real-life scenario where you would use EMOType? Please describe a concrete example.
- **Q10:** Looking at the six modes overall, how did you perceive the differences between them? Did they feel like distinct categories to you, or was there a gradual progression?
- **Q11:** Regarding the mode you ranked highest (in Q1): Why did you choose it as the best? Can you describe specific visual elements that resonated with you?
- **Q12:** Regarding the mode you ranked lowest (in Q1): Why did you consider it the worst? Which specific visual elements did you find unappealing or distracting?
- **Q13:** Did you encounter any styles that successfully conveyed emotion but negatively impacted readability? Please explain which ones and why.
- **Q14:** If you were the designer, how would you improve the current visual effects to make them better?

C User Study Demographics

Table 2: Demographic Information of Participants ($N = 25$). *Voice Typing Usage* refers to the frequency of using speech-to-text features in daily life (1=Daily, 2=Weekly, 3=Monthly).

ID	Gender	Age	Education	Voice Typing Usage
P1	Female	20	Bachelor	Daily
P2	Female	21	Bachelor	Daily
P3	Male	22	Bachelor	Weekly
P4	Male	22	Bachelor	Weekly
P5	Male	20	Bachelor	Weekly
P6	Male	21	Bachelor	Monthly
P7	Female	21	Bachelor	Monthly
P8	Female	22	Bachelor	Monthly
P9	Female	20	Bachelor	Daily
P10	Male	20	Bachelor	Daily
P11	Female	21	Bachelor	Daily
P12	Male	25	PhD	Daily
P13	Female	25	Master	Weekly

ID	Gender	Age	Education	Voice Typing Usage
P14	Male	28	PhD	Weekly
P15	Male	22	Master	Weekly
P16	Female	24	Master	Daily
P17	Female	21	Bachelor	Weekly
P18	Male	25	Master	Daily
P19	Male	24	Master	Daily
P20	Male	23	Master	Monthly
P21	Male	23	Master	Monthly
P22	Male	29	PhD	Monthly
P23	Male	20	Bachelor	Daily
P24	Male	21	Bachelor	Daily
P25	Male	36	PhD	Monthly

